THE MERCENARY'S FIELD MANUAL

Simplified Campaign Rules for Classic BattleTech

Pilot Advancement • Company Management • Contract Generation • Repairs & Salvage

Streamlined from, and compatible with, Campaign Operations

1. How This Campaign Works

These rules replace the full Campaign Operations bookkeeping with a lean system for running a lance-to-company sized mercenary command (4–12 BattleMechs). They keep the shape and vocabulary of the official rules — C-bills, skill ratings, contract clauses, tech teams — so you can graduate to the full book (or import pieces of it) at any time without converting your campaign.

You will need the Total Warfare / BattleMech Manual rules for the battles themselves, a record sheet for each 'Mech, and a company ledger (a notebook page or spreadsheet is fine). All costs are in C-bills, rounded to friendly numbers.

The Campaign Month

The campaign runs in months. Each month, work through this sequence:

1. **Contracts.** If unemployed, look for work and negotiate offers (Section 4). If under contract, note this month's obligations.
2. **Missions.** Play the month's battles, set by the contract's operational tempo. Track damage, kills, and objectives.
3. **Repair & Refit.** Tech teams fix the machines and pilots heal (Sections 2 and 5).
4. **Payday.** Collect contract pay and salvage income; pay monthly expenses (Section 3). Update the ledger.
5. **Advancement.** Spend pilot XP, recruit personnel, buy equipment, and adjust company Reputation.

> **Design note**
>
> Whenever these rules and your table disagree, your table wins. Every number here is deliberately round: if the group wants grittier economics or faster advancement, tune the multipliers rather than adding subsystems.

2. Pilot Advancement

Every MechWarrior is defined by two skills — Gunnery and Piloting — plus wounds and any Special Abilities. Lower is better, exactly as in the core rules.

Experience Ratings

Rating	Typical Gunnery / Piloting	Notes
Green	5 / 6	Fresh from academy or the family farm
Regular	4 / 5	The line standard for House and merc units
Veteran	3 / 4	Survived enough battles to have habits
Elite	2 / 3	Names that show up in enemy briefings

A pilot's rating is determined by combined skill total (Gunnery + Piloting): **10+ Green, 8–9 Regular, 6–7 Veteran, 5 or less Elite.**

Earning XP

Each pilot earns XP individually, awarded at the end of every battle:

Event	XP
Took part in the battle	1
Destroyed or crippled an enemy unit (max 2 per battle)	1 each
Directly accomplished a scenario objective	1
Standout performance — group's call, max one pilot per battle	1
Completed a full contract (awarded at contract end)	1

A typical battle is worth 1–3 XP; a great one is worth 5. Pilots keep their XP individually — it is not pooled.

Spending XP

During the Advancement step, a pilot may improve **one skill by one point** by paying the cost of the new value. Limit one improvement per pilot per month; no skill may drop below 1.

New Skill Value	Gunnery Cost (XP)	Piloting Cost (XP)
5	4	2
4	6	4
3	9	6
2	13	9
1	18	13

Example: *Improving Gunnery from 4 to 3 costs 9 XP — three or four battles of solid performance. This table is tuned for groups that play a mission or so per month of real time; double the costs if your campaign runs faster than your calendar.*

Special Pilot Abilities (Optional)

A pilot gains one free ability when they first reach **Veteran** (skill total 7 or less) and a second on reaching **Elite** (total 5 or less). Alternatively a pilot may buy an ability for **20 XP**. Maximum two abilities per pilot. These are simplified versions of official SPAs — swap in the full versions from Campaign Operations if you prefer.

Ability	Effect
Sniper	Halve range modifiers on this pilot's weapon attacks (round up).
Dodge	Attacks against this pilot suffer +1 to-hit in any turn they ran or jumped.
Melee Specialist	−2 to-hit on this pilot's physical attacks.
Toughness	−2 target number on this pilot's consciousness rolls.
Edge	Once per battle, reroll any one of your own dice rolls; keep the second result.
Hot Dog	+2 on rolls to avoid heat-related shutdown and heat-triggered ammo explosions.

Wounds, Healing, and Ejection

- **Wounds.** Each pilot hit taken in battle is one wound. A pilot with 6 wounds is dead. Wounds persist between battles until healed.
- **Healing.** With medical care (a doctor on staff or a friendly facility), one wound heals per week. Without care, one per two weeks. A wounded pilot may still deploy — at their own risk.
- **Ejection.** When a pilot punches out over the battlefield, roll 2d6 after the battle: on a 2 they are captured or missing (ransom, rescue, or a new hire — your story); on 3–4 they land badly and take one additional wound; on 5+ they are recovered safely. Any wounds already taken remain.
- **Replacements.** Dead or missing pilots are replaced through hiring (Section 3). New characters start with 0 XP.

3. Company Management

The company is tracked with a simple monthly ledger: income in, expenses out, and a Reputation score that shapes what work you can get.

Monthly Expenses

Every month — employed or not — pay the following. If you cannot pay, see Debt below.

Expense	Monthly Cost (C-bills)
MechWarrior salary	Green 1,000 · Regular 1,500 · Veteran 2,500 · Elite 4,000
Tech team (one required per 'Mech)	2,000 (Veteran team 3,000 · Elite team 4,500)
Spares & maintenance, per 'Mech	50 × the 'Mech's tonnage
Overhead (admin, food, medical, ammo allowance)	+10% of the subtotal, rounded up to the nearest 500

Worked example

Barton's Bulldogs field a lance: Phoenix Hawk (45t), Shadow Hawk (55t), Rifleman (60t), and Battlemaster (85t), all Regular pilots with Regular tech teams.

Salaries 4 × 1,500 = 6,000 · Tech teams 4 × 2,000 = 8,000 · Spares 245 tons × 50 = 12,250 · Subtotal 26,250 · Overhead +2,625 → rounds to 29,000 C-bills/month.

This number — the company's **Monthly Expenses** — also drives contract pay in Section 4, so keep it current on the ledger.

Reputation

Reputation is a 0–10 score; a new command starts at **3 (Unproven)**. It is the simplified equivalent of a Dragoons Rating and feeds directly into contract negotiation.

Score	Standing	Negotiation Modifier
0–1	Dubious	−2 (and −2 on Employer rolls — only the desperate hire you)
2–3	Unproven	+0
4–5	Reliable	+1
6–7	Respected	+2 (and +1 contract offer when searching for work)
8–9	Renowned	+3 (and +1 contract offer when searching for work)
10	Legendary	+4 (employers come to you)

Adjust Reputation at the end of each contract:

Outcome	Change
Contract completed successfully	+1
Exceptional success (all objectives met, employer delighted)	+1 additional
Contract failed	−1
Breach of contract (you walked, defected, or refused orders)	−2
Lost more than half your 'Mechs during the contract	−1 (word gets around)

Hiring Personnel

- **Where.** Recruiting requires a world with a hiring hall — any major world, regional capital, or mercenary hub (Galatea, Outreach, Solaris VII).
- **MechWarriors.** Each month spent recruiting, 1d6 ÷ 2 (round up) candidates are available. Roll 2d6 for each candidate's rating: 2–6 Green, 7–9 Regular, 10–11 Veteran, 12 Elite. Candidates are Dispossessed (no 'Mech) unless you roll a 12 — an Elite hire brings their own ride but demands 25% of your salvage share as a rider.
- **Signing bonus.** New MechWarriors cost a one-time bonus equal to two months' salary.
- **Techs and staff.** Regular tech teams and medics can be hired freely on any hiring-hall world; Veteran and Elite teams appear on a 2d6 roll of 9+ each month.
- **Specialists.** A **negotiator** (2,500 C-bills/month) adds +1 to contract negotiation rolls — the same weight as two points of Reputation. A **surgeon or medic** (1,500 C-bills/month) provides the medical care that heals wounds in one week instead of two.

Buying and Selling Hardware

- **Finding a 'Mech.** On a hiring-hall world, roll 2d6 ≥ 8 to find a 'Mech of a desired weight class for sale that month (+2 near a factory world or major capital, −2 in the Periphery). The exact model is the market's choice, not yours.
- **Price.** Roll 1d6: 1–2 = 110% of book value, 3–4 = 100%, 5–6 = 90%.
- **Selling.** A working 'Mech sells for 75% of book value; an unrestored salvage hulk for 25%. Parts and weapons sell at half list.
- **Debt.** You may carry debt up to three months' expenses at 10% interest per month. Exceed that, and the company is dissolved, seized, or flees to the Periphery — campaign over, or a very different campaign begins.

4. Contract Generation

When the company is unemployed and on a hiring-hall world, generate contract offers during the Contracts step. Roll 1d6 ÷ 2 (round up) offers, +1 if Reputation is 6+, −1 if Reputation is 0–1 (minimum zero — some months nobody calls). Generate each offer with the five steps below, negotiate the ones you like, then sign one or keep looking.

Step 1 — Employer (2d6)

2d6	Employer	Pay ×	Quirks
2–3	Shady broker / pirate backer	×1.4	+2 on Salvage roll; Support is always None; 2d6 on completion: on 2–4 they try to stiff you
4–5	Planetary government	×0.9	−1 on Transport roll; grateful locals
6–8	Great House	×1.0	+1 on Support roll; deep pockets, long paperwork
9–10	Corporation	×1.1	−1 on Salvage roll (they own everything); pays on time
11	Periphery realm	×0.9	+2 on Salvage roll; pay may arrive as goods
12	ComStar	×1.3	Transport is always Full; asks no questions, answers none

Reputation 0–1 commands apply −2 to this roll (minimum 2).

Step 2 — Mission Type (2d6)

2d6	Mission	Pay ×	Length	Tempo
2	Guerrilla campaign	×2.0	1d6+6 months	High
3	Covert / special operation	×1.8	1d6 months	High
4	Planetary assault	×1.5	1d6+3 months	High
5	Extraction / rescue raid	×1.5	2 months	Medium
6	Objective raid	×1.5	2 months	Medium
7	Garrison duty	×1.0	1d6+6 months	Low
8	Security / escort duty	×1.1	1d6+2 months	Low
9	Recon raid	×1.4	2 months	Medium
10	Pirate hunting	×1.1	1d6+2 months	Medium
11	Relief / defensive duty	×1.3	1d6+3 months	Medium
12	Cadre (training) duty	×0.8	1d6+3 months	Low

Operational tempo sets the battles per month: **Low** = 1 battle (a second on a 2d6 roll of 9+); **Medium** = 2 battles; **High** = 3 battles. The employer's objectives define the scenarios — pick or roll from any scenario source you like.

Step 3 — Pay

Contract pay formula

Monthly pay = 2 × your Monthly Expenses × Mission multiplier × Employer multiplier

Pay lands at the end of each month. On signing, the employer advances one month's pay, deducted from the final month. Round everything to the nearest 1,000 C-bills.

Example: Barton's Bulldogs (expenses 29,000) take an Objective Raid (×1.5) for a Corporation (×1.1): 2 × 29,000 × 1.5 × 1.1 ≈ 96,000 C-bills/month for 2 months.

Step 4 — Contract Clauses (1d6 each)

Roll 1d6 on each column, applying any employer quirks. These four clauses are where negotiation matters most.

1d6	Command	Salvage	Support	Transport
1	House command	None	None	None
2	House command	Exchange	None	None
3	Liaison	Exchange	Partial	Half
4	Liaison	Shared	Partial	Half
5	Independent	Shared	Full	Full
6	Independent	Full	Full	Full

Clause	What it means
Command	House: employer's officers give orders, refusal risks breach. Liaison: an employer rep tags along and requests, not orders. Independent: you fight it your way.
Salvage	None: battlefield belongs to the employer. Exchange: turn everything over; employer pays 40% of its value in C-bills. Shared: keep up to half (alternate picks with the employer). Full: everything you can drag home is yours.
Support	Partial: employer reimburses 50% of repair and replacement-part costs incurred on the contract. Full: 100% reimbursed. Claims are settled at contract end.
Transport	Employer covers none, half, or all of your DropShip/JumpShip passage. Transport costs 2,500 C-bills per 'Mech per jump; the contract world is 1d6+1 jumps away, each way.

Step 5 — Negotiation

- One roll per offer: **2d6 + Reputation modifier vs. target 8** (+1 with a negotiator on staff — see Section 3).
- **Success:** improve any one clause by one step (e.g., Salvage from Exchange to Shared), or take +10% pay instead. Every 3 full points of margin buys one additional improvement.
- **Fail by 5+ or roll snake eyes:** the employer is insulted — worsen one randomly determined clause by one step. You may still sign or walk away.

Wrapping Up a Contract

Result	Definition	Effect
Success	You met the contract's main objectives across the campaign	+1 Reputation; final pay in full
Exceptional	Success, plus every major objective and no breach of discipline	+2 Reputation total; +10% completion bonus
Failure	Main objectives not met	−1 Reputation; final month paid at half
Breach	You abandoned or violated the contract	−2 Reputation; forfeit final month and any Support claims

Optional: Monthly Events (2d6)

Once per month while on contract, roll 2d6 for a complication or windfall:

2d6	Event
2	Pay dispute — this month's pay arrives only if you roll 8+ on 2d6 next month (back-paid on success)
3	Supply shortage — all parts and ammo cost +50% this month
4	Local unrest — one extra battle this month at the usual pay
5–9	Quiet month — no event
10	Friendly militia — an allied militia lance (Green) supports you in one battle
11	Hidden cache — discover supplies worth 1d6 × 10,000 C-bills
12	Good press — +1 Reputation if this contract ends in Success

5. Repairs & Salvage

After each battle, tally the damage on each 'Mech's record sheet and put its tech team to work. Each 'Mech has one dedicated tech team, and a team works one task at a time.

The Tech Roll

> **Tech roll**
>
> **2d6 + Tech Team modifier + Facility modifier ≥ task Target Number**
>
> **Tech teams:** Green −1 · Regular +0 · Veteran +1 · Elite +2
>
> **Facilities:** Field conditions −1 · DropShip or 'Mech bay +0 · Proper industrial facility +1
>
> **Failure:** the task takes double time; roll again when that time is up. **Snake eyes (natural 2):** botched — a component under repair is ruined and must be replaced instead; structure or location work instead costs +50%.

Repair Tasks

Tasks marked Auto need no roll — just time and money. Time assumes one team on the job.

Task	TN	Time	Cost (C-bills)
Reload ammunition	Auto	½ day	5,000 per ton (specialty munitions ×2)
Patch armor	Auto	1 day per 20 points	500 per point
Repair internal structure	7	1 day per location	2,000 per point
Repair a critted component	8	1 day	25% of the item's value (min. 2,000)
Replace a destroyed component	7	1 day	Item's full value — requires the part
Repair an actuator	8	1 day	10,000
Repair engine damage	9	2 days	25,000 per hit
Repair gyro damage	9	2 days	30,000 per hit
Repair sensors / life support / cockpit	8	1 day	15,000
Reattach an intact blown-off limb	8	2 days	5,000
Rebuild a destroyed location	9	1 week	10% of the 'Mech's book value — requires parts

- **Rush jobs.** A team may work around the clock: two tasks per day, but every roll takes +1 to its target number.
- **Downtime.** If the company spends a full month off contract, assume every repair attempt succeeds and all work finishes — just pay the bill.
- **Support clauses.** Under Partial or Full support (Section 4), log repair and part costs during the contract and claim reimbursement at the end.

Parts and Availability

- **Common parts** (armor, ammo, structure, actuators, heat sinks, and the standard weapons below) are available on any inhabited world at list price.
- **Rare parts** (ER and pulse weapons, XL engines, Endo Steel, anything lostech): roll 2d6 ≥ 8 each month to source one (+2 on a major industrial world, −2 in the Periphery). Otherwise wait, or pay a broker double.

Component	Cost	Component	Cost
Small Laser	11,000	AC/2	75,000

Component	Cost	Component	Cost
Medium Laser	40,000	AC/5	125,000
Large Laser	100,000	AC/10	200,000
PPC	200,000	AC/20	300,000
SRM-2 / SRM-4 / SRM-6	10,000 / 60,000 / 80,000	LRM-5 / LRM-10	30,000 / 100,000
Machine Gun	5,000	LRM-15 / LRM-20	175,000 / 250,000
Heat Sink	2,000	Jump Jet	200 × 'Mech tonnage

Salvage and Rebuilding

- **Claiming the field.** Your Salvage clause (Section 4) governs what you may keep from any battlefield you hold at the end of a scenario.
- **Downed 'Mechs.** A 'Mech that lost its pilot but is structurally intact is salvaged as-is — repair it per its record sheet.
- **Destroyed 'Mechs** (centre torso gone, engine destroyed, or ammunition catastrophe): roll 1d6 — on 4+ the wreck is recoverable as a hulk; otherwise it is scrap worth 5% of book value.
- **Restoring a hulk** costs (1d6+4) × 5% of the 'Mech's book value and takes 2d6 weeks of one tech team's time. Until restored it is a hulk (sells for 25% of book value).
- **Selling salvage.** Working 'Mechs sell for 75% of book value, hulks for 25%, loose parts and weapons at half list. Under an Exchange clause the employer pays 40% of value for everything turned over.

6. Quick Reference

The Month in Brief

1. **Contracts —** search (1d6÷2 offers), generate, negotiate (2d6 + Rep vs 8), sign.
2. **Missions —** fight battles per tempo: Low 1 · Medium 2 · High 3.
3. **Repair & Refit —** tech rolls 2d6 + mods vs task TN; pilots heal 1 wound/week.
4. **Payday —** income: 2 × Expenses × Mission × Employer, plus salvage. Outgo: salaries, tech teams, 50 × tonnage spares, +10% overhead.
5. **Advancement —** spend XP (one skill step per pilot), recruit, shop, adjust Reputation.

Key Rolls

Roll	Dice	Target / Read-out
Contract negotiation	2d6 + Rep modifier	8+ = improve a clause or +10% pay; every 3 over = 1 more
Tech roll	2d6 + team + facility	Task TN (7–9); fail = double time; nat. 2 = botch
Find a 'Mech for sale	2d6	8+ (+2 factory world, −2 Periphery)
Source a rare part	2d6	8+ (+2 industrial world, −2 Periphery)
Recruit quality	2d6	2–6 Green · 7–9 Regular · 10–11 Veteran · 12 Elite
Ejected pilot	2d6	2 captured · 3–4 +1 wound · 5+ safe
Destroyed 'Mech salvage	1d6	4+ recoverable hulk
Second battle (Low tempo)	2d6	9+

Company Ledger Template

Line	This Month
Contract pay (2 × Expenses × Mission × Employer)	
Salvage / sales / other income	
Salaries (pilots)	
Tech teams	
Spares & maintenance (50 × total tonnage)	
Overhead (+10%, round up to 500)	
Repairs, parts & ammo	
Transport (2,500 × 'Mechs × jumps, less employer share)	
Hiring bonuses / purchases / debt interest	
Net change to treasury	

Good hunting, Commander. *May your contracts pay on time and your salvage clause always read 'Full'.*